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Metadata for Current National Occurrence of Feral Deer in Australia (2026), version 1.0.0

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Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the Traditional Custodians of Australia and their continuing connection to land and sea, waters, environment and community. We pay our respects to the Traditional Custodians of the lands we live and work on, their culture, and their Elders past and present.

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Summary

Current National Occurrence of Feral Deer in Australia (2026) is a collection of continental spatial datasets of the gridded current known occurrence of feral deer in Australia. It contains maps of the known occurrence of each species of deer in Australia: chital deer (*Axis axis*), hog deer (*Axis porcinus*), fallow deer (*Dama dama*), red deer (*Cervus elaphus*), rusa deer (*Cervus timorensis*) and sambar deer (*Cervus unicolor*), and the combined known occurrence of all deer in Australia. This document contains metadata for these spatial datasets, comprising of standard metadata fields, a summary of the contents of the data package, and information about the lineage of these datasets including a summary of the methods used to produce them and a list of all contributing data sources.

Accompanying datasets, *Current National Relative Abundance of Fallow Deer in Australia (2026)* and *Current National Relative Abundance of Sambar Deer in Australia (2026)* are also available from the ABARES website, which contain the modelled current relative abundance of fallow deer and sambar deer in Australia.

Standard metadata

Dataset	
Resource title	*Current National Occurrence of Feral Deer in Australia (2026)* dataset
Citation	Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences 2026, *Current National Occurrence of Feral Deer in Australia (2026),* Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences, Canberra, April, https://doi.org/10.25814/bzzm-tt25. CC BY 4.0.
Digital object identifier (DOI)	https://doi.org/10.25814/bzzm-tt25
Custodian/contact information	
Custodian	Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry – Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences (ABARES)
Jurisdiction	Australia
Contact organisation	ABARES
Address	GPO Box 858 Canberra ACT Australia 2601
Email	info.ABARES@aff.gov.au
Description/Data Quality/Data Currency/Dataset Status	
Abstract	The *Current National Occurrence of Feral Deer in Australia (2026)* dataset contains maps of the known occurrence of each species of deer in Australia: chital deer (*Axis axis*), hog deer (*Axis porcinus*), fallow deer (*Dama dama*), red deer (*Cervus elaphus*), rusa deer (*Cervus timorensis*) and sambar deer (*Cervus unicolor*), and the combined known occurrence of all deer in Australia. These maps are aggregated to a national grid at a resolution of 20 km x 20 km. This dataset was produced from a collaboration between the Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences (ABARES) and data contributors, as part of the *National Vertebrate Pests and Weeds Distribution Project*. The project was supported with funding from the Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry's Established Pest Animals and Weeds Management Pipeline Program and Supporting Communities Manage Pest Animals and Weeds Program.
Purpose	To provide national scale gridded maps that represent the known occurrence of feral deer in Australia. This dataset should not be used to plan local-scale control or monitoring efforts.
ANZLIC search words	FAUNA FAUNA Exotic FAUNA Vertebrates HAZARDS HAZARDS Pests ECOLOGY AGRICULTURE
Keywords	Chital deer Hog deer Fallow deer Red deer Rusa deer Sambar deer Feral deer *Axis axis* *Axis porcinus* *Dama dama* *Cervus elaphus*

	Cervus timorensis *Cervus unicolor* Vertebrate pest Distribution Occurrence Australia
Lineage	The dataset provides national gridded maps of known feral deer species occurrence in Australia. Data were collated from Commonwealth, state and territory government agencies and other sources ranging from research institutions to citizen science platforms, along with jurisdictional expert opinion data where available. A detailed description of the lineage, including the methods used to generate the dataset and a full list of all input data sources, is provided at the end of this document.
Publication date	21 April 2026
Currency	Currency of individual datasets that contributed to this dataset varies. Last date at which data collection occurred ranges from 2013 – 2026.
Data file name	See Data Package Contents
Stored data format	Geotiff (raster) files for each species and all deer created using R 4.4.1, associated layer file formats for ArcGIS Pro (.lyrx) and QGIS (.qlr) and supporting documentation– zipped
Compressed file size	0.55 MB
Geographic extent	Australia excluding external territories. Spatial bounding box: North: -1,001,000 m South: -4,841,000 m East: 2,132,000 m West: -1,888,000 m
Spatial resolution/ cell size	20 x 20 kilometres
Spatial reference	ESPG:3577 GDA94 Australian Albers Coordinate system: GDA_1994_Albers False Easting: 0 False Northing: 0 Central meridian: 132° Standard parallels: -18°, -36° Latitude of origin: 0° Datum: D_GDA_1994
Positional accuracy	Known deer occurrences are aggregated to cells with a 20 km x 20 km resolution.
Attribute accuracy	The dataset provides national gridded maps of known feral deer species occurrence in Australia at a coarse 20 km × 20 km grid. It does not reflect patterns of distribution at finer scales and it may in some areas be a slight overrepresentation of the true extent of deer distribution in Australia. The dataset is unlikely to accurately reflect the current feral deer distribution where recent lethal suppression efforts, eradication programs, range expansions, or accidental or illegal releases have taken place. Species scientific names used within this mapping align with the taxonomy in the Australian Faunal Directory. Some data sources use synonyms (e.g. *Rusa unicolor* for sambar deer, *Rusa timorensis* for rusa deer, *Cervus porcinus* for hog deer, *Cervus axis* for chital deer, *Cervus dama* for fallow deer). Verified records using accepted synonyms have also been included in this dataset.
Completeness	The dataset provides coverage of mainland Australia and Tasmania. Records from Australian islands other than Tasmania were only included where state and territory governments identified populations on those islands as currently established and notable.
Update frequency	Not known
Access	
Licencing	Creative Commons by Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0)
Access constraints	No restriction, nil cost.
Use constraints	CC BY 4.0 permits:

	Share – users may copy and redistribute the material in any medium or format. Adapt – users may remix, transform, and build upon the material for any purpose, even commercially. Attribution – users must give appropriate credit using the citation listed, provide a link to the licence, and indicate if changes were made. Users may do so in any reasonable manner, but not in any way that suggests the licensor endorses the use.
Security constraints	Classification: Unclassified
Legal constraints	The Australian Government acting through the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, represented by the Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences, has exercised due care and skill in preparing and compiling the information and data in this publication. Notwithstanding, the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, ABARES, its employees and advisers disclaim all liability, including liability for negligence and for any loss, damage, injury, expense or cost incurred by any person as a result of accessing, using or relying on any of the information or data in this publication to the maximum extent permitted by law.
Metadata date/ Additional metadata	
Metadata date	21 April 2026 (version 1.0.0)
Additional metadata	The following additional metadata is included: 1. A list of data package contents 2. Documentation of the dataset lineage, including the methodology, interpretation and use of the dataset, and a list of all datasets that were used as input.

Data package contents

A zipped data package is provided (**FeralDeerOccurrence2026_data_v1.0.0.zip**) containing the following files:

- Raster files (geotiff format) showing current known occurrence of feral deer species in Australia:
    - **ChitalDeerOccurrence2026.tif**. Occurrence of chital deer (*Axis axis*) in Australia
    - **HogDeerOccurrence2026.tif**. Occurrence of hog deer (*Axis porcinus*) in Australia
    - **FallowDeerOccurrence2026.tif**. Occurrence of fallow deer (*Dama dama*) in Australia
    - **RedDeerOccurrence2026.tif**. Occurrence of red deer (*Cervus elaphus*) in Australia
    - **RusaDeerOccurrence2026.tif**. Occurrence of rusa deer (*Cervus timorensis*) in Australia
    - **SambarDeerOccurrence2026.tif**. Occurrence of sambar deer (*Cervus unicolor*) in Australia
    - **AllDeerOccurrence2026.tif**. Occurrence of all deer species in Australia
- ArcGIS Pro layer files for each raster to enable data to be viewed with the same formatting used in the published map images.
    - **ChitalDeerOccurrence2026.lyrx**
    - **HogDeerOccurrence2026.lyrx**
    - **FallowDeerOccurrence2026.lyrx**
    - **RedDeerOccurrence2026.lyrx**
    - **RusaDeerOccurrence2026.lyrx**
    - **SambarDeerOccurrence2026.lyrx**
    - **AllDeerOccurrence2026.lyrx**
- QGIS layer files for each raster to enable data to be viewed with the same formatting used in the published map images:
    - **ChitalDeerOccurrence2026.qlr**
    - **HogDeerOccurrence2026.qlr**
    - **FallowDeerOccurrence2026.qlr**
    - **RedDeerOccurrence2026.qlr**
    - **RusaDeerOccurrence2026.qlr**
    - **SambarDeerOccurrence2026.qlr**
    - **AllDeerOccurrence2026.qlr**
- Metadata document
    - **FeralDeerOccurrence2026_meta_v1.0.0.pdf**

Each raster file has three possible values:

- 1 indicates that one or more verified occurrence point records fell within that cell. These cells are labelled as “Present based on verified point records” in the maps and layer files.
- 2 indicates that no verified occurrence point records occurred within the cell but the cell overlaps with additional areas of distribution identified by systematic expert opinion mapping programs in NSW and Queensland. These cells are labelled as “Present based on state mapping” in the maps and layer files.
- NA indicates that no verified occurrence point records or expert opinion occurs within the cell.

Lineage

1.1 Introduction

The *Current National Occurrence of Feral Deer in Australia (2026)* dataset consists of maps of the known occurrence of each species of deer in Australia: chital deer (*Axis axis*), hog deer (*Axis porcinus*), fallow deer (*Dama dama*), red deer (*Cervus elaphus*), rusa deer (*Cervus timorensis*) and sambar deer (*Cervus unicolor*), and the combined known occurrence of all deer in Australia. The purpose of this dataset is to provide coarse-scale national maps of current feral deer occurrence by collating verified data from jurisdictional agencies and other data sources using a national grid.

1.2 Methods

1.2.1 Study area

The *Current National Occurrence of Feral Deer in Australia (2026)* dataset covers mainland Australia and Tasmania. Records from other Australian islands were only included where state and territory governments identified populations on those islands as currently established and notable. For a more comprehensive list of the invasive fauna of Australian islands, see the Department of Climate Change, Energy and Environment's database of feral animals on offshore islands.

1.2.2 Occurrence data

The dataset has been created using two types of occurrence data that have been aggregated using a 20 km x 20 km national grid. The primary data type is deer occurrence point records that have been collated by ABARES and verified by relevant experts. Cells that contain verified deer occurrence point records are shown in dark green on the national maps. The second data type is jurisdictional expert opinion data on deer distribution produced by systematic state-wide expert opinion maps. Cells which do not contain verified deer occurrence point records but do overlap with areas of deer distribution mapped by expert opinion maps are shown in light green on the national maps.

Collation and processing of point records

Deer occurrence point records were collated from 36 sources including Australian state and territory government agencies and other sources ranging from research institutions to citizen science platforms. Records from unverified sources (e.g. anecdotal observations or media reports) were not included in the mapping. A full list of data sources is provided in Table 1.

To ensure accuracy, records were verified by deer experts in each jurisdiction. Experts were asked to identify any records that were incorrect, were from a population that had been extirpated at the time of review, or that were likely to be roaming individuals that did not represent a currently established population.

All verified records for each deer species were then collated and intersected with a 20 km x 20 km national grid. Grid cells were marked as present when one or more verified records of a species occurred within that cell. For the combined all deer map and dataset, cells were marked as present when one or more verified records of any deer species occurred within that cell, including deer occurrence records that were not identified or recorded to the individual species level.

Collation and processing of expert opinion data

Expert opinion mapping from two jurisdictional state-wide mapping datasets was used as a data source for this dataset (Table 1). Jurisdictional expert opinion datasets were only included if they were produced within the last five years by a systematic state-wide consultation process using a grid-based framework (i.e. the state is divided into a regular grid which is used as the basis for consultation and the production of maps) and were available for individual deer species.

The state-wide maps used different resolutions and projections to this dataset. To align these maps with the 20 km x 20 km national grid, the amount of area mapped as present by the state-wide mapping datasets was calculated for each cell. If the calculated present area was at least half of the input cell area from the relevant state dataset, that cell was marked as present. This threshold was chosen to avoid exaggerating the extent by including cells that only had a small amount of overlap.

1.3 Use and limitations of the data

This dataset should be used as a broad-scale indication of deer occurrence in Australia. It is indicative only and should not be used to plan local-scale control or monitoring efforts. Deer records have been aggregated to a coarse 20 km × 20 km grid and do not reflect patterns of distribution at finer scales. Aggregation will produce a slight overrepresentation of extent in areas where the true boundary of the distribution falls within a cell.

While every effort has been made to ensure that the dataset is correct at the time of publication, it is unlikely to accurately reflect the current distribution of feral deer where recent lethal suppression efforts, eradication programs, range expansions, or accidental or illegal releases have taken place, as the data available for mapping inherently lag the true distribution of the species. In particular, the South Australian government is currently conducting a state-wide deer eradication program (PIRSA 2023) which aims for population reductions followed by total eradication by 2032.

Hybridisation between deer species can pose a problem for the accuracy of distribution maps for individual species. While no records from individuals that were known hybrids were included in the species-level datasets, animals are often identified to species based on morphological characteristics, which can be highly variable in hybrid animals. Thus, it is possible that some hybrid individuals may have been included in these datasets for particular species. For example, some hybrid rusa-sambar individuals may have been included in the maps for either rusa deer (*Cervus timorensis*) or sambar deer (*Cervus unicolor*) in regions where the species overlap. Genetic data suggests that all of Victoria's hog deer (*Axis porcinus*) population have hybrid origins with chital deer (*Axis axis*) (Hill et al. 2019). However, as this hybridisation was historical and is not ongoing in Victoria, individuals have simply been mapped as hog deer in this dataset.

More information and updates about the occurrence and abundance of feral deer can also be obtained from state and territory government primary industries and environment departments. Recent work from the Arthur Rylah institute has modelled the distribution and abundance on public lands of the four main deer species (fallow, red, sambar and hog deer) which occur in Victoria (Cally & Ramsey 2023). The NSW and Queensland governments regularly produce maps of deer species in their states based on consultation with land and pest management organisations (DPIRD NSW distribution maps for vertebrate pests and DPI Qld annual pest distribution survey). Although these

datasets have been incorporated as expert opinion data into this dataset, the original mapping for both programs is at a higher resolution and contains further information about abundance.

Table 1. Deer occurrence datasets that were used as input to the *Current National Occurrence of Feral Deer in Australia (2026)* dataset.

Data custodian	Description	Date range
Atlas of Living Australia	Atlas of Living Australia, *Cervidae* occurrence records, accessed 29 January 2026	1965-2026
FeralScan – Developed by the Centre for Invasive Species Solutions	Records of deer activity and sightings from citizen science tool. Mix of indirect evidence (sign, scat, etc.) and direct sightings	2010-2023
Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry	Deer records from landholder surveys, 2019 and 2022	2019, 2022
Northern Australian Quarantine Strategy, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry	Deer records from monitoring, control and/or incidental sources	2017-2020
Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water, NSW	Deer records from camera trapping surveys in NSW national parks. Data is from the NPWS WildCount fauna monitoring program, downloaded at NSW Bionet	2012-2021
Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water, NSW	Deer records from aerial surveys monitoring macropod populations	2020-2023
National Parks and Wildlife Service, Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water, NSW	Deer records from monitoring, control and/or incidental sources	2004-2023
Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water, NSW	NSW Bionet, *Cervidae* occurrence records, accessed 11 June 2025	1977-2025
Local Land Services, NSW	Deer records from monitoring, control and/or incidental sources	2016-2025
Department of Primary Industries and Regional Development, NSW	Statewide distribution mapping for chital, fallow, red, rusa and sambar deer and all deer species, based on expert opinion	2023
Department of Lands, Planning and Environment, NT	NT Fauna atlas, *Cervus unicolor* occurrence records, accessed 21 February 2025	2014
Department of the Environment, Tourism, Science and Innovation, QLD	Wildnet database, *Cervidae* occurrence records, accessed 30 April 2025	1870-2023
Department of the Environment, Tourism, Science and Innovation, QLD	Deer records from camera trapping surveys conducted across the Gondwana network of National Parks, QLD, provided by Harry Hines	2012-2021

Department of the Environment, Tourism, Science and Innovation, QLD	Deer records from aerial surveys monitoring macropod populations	2021-2022
Department of Primary Industries, QLD	Statewide distribution mapping led by Biosecurity Queensland for chital, fallow, red and rusa deer, based on expert opinion (workshops with and review by pest experts including representatives from Local Government, NRM bodies and other agencies)	2023
Department for Environment and Water, SA	Biological Databases of South Australia, *Cervidae* occurrence records, accessed 13 May 2025	1971-2025
Department of Natural Resources and Environment, TAS	Deer records from annual state-wide spotlight transect surveys monitoring populations of wild native and non-native species	1975-2022
Department of Natural Resources and Environment, TAS	Natural Values Atlas Tasmania, *Dama dama* occurrence records, accessed 18 August 2025	1975-2024
Department of Natural Resources and Environment, TAS	Deer records from camera trapping surveys in Tasmania	2019-2021
DEEP Lab, University of Tasmania	Deer records from camera trapping surveys carried out by the DEEP lab (University of Tasmania)	2018-2022
School of Natural Sciences, University of Tasmania	Deer records from camera trapping surveys carried out as part of the PhD research of Antje Chiu Werner, Calum Cunningham, Rowena Hamer, Riana Gardiner and Glen Bain (University of Tasmania)	2015-2019
State Government of Victoria	Victorian Biodiversity Atlas, *Cervidae* occurrence records, accessed 7 January 2026	1866-2025
Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action, VIC	Deer records from the Glenelg Ark camera trapping program	2013-2019
Parks Victoria	Deer records from the Otway Ark camera trapping program (2016-2018) and camera grids in the Otways region (2025)	2016-2025
Parks Victoria	Deer records from monitoring, control and/or incidental sources	2020-2024
Arthur Rylah Institute, Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action, VIC	Deer records from camera trapping surveys collected for evaluating the distribution and abundance of deer on Victorian public lands	2021-2023
Quantitative and Applied Ecology Group, University of Melbourne	Deer records from camera trapping surveys collected as part of the PhD research of Matthew Rees (University of Melbourne)	2017-2019
Department of Primary Industries and Regional Development, WA & **Department of Biodiversity, Conservation and Attractions, WA**	Deer records from monitoring, control and/or incidental sources across WA	1999-2026
Department of Biodiversity, Conservation and Attractions, WA	Deer records from monitoring, control and/or incidental sources in southwest WA	1999-2024
Department of Biodiversity, Conservation and Attractions, WA	Deer records from camera trapping surveys in the southwest NRM region of WA	2017-2022

Department of Primary Industries and Rural Development, WA	Deer records from camera trapping surveys across WA	2020-2024
Department of Biodiversity, Conservation and Attractions, WA	Dandjoo, *Dama dama* occurrence records, accessed 24 July 2025	2014
Department of Biodiversity, Conservation and Attractions, WA	NatureMap WA, *Dama dama* occurrence records, supplied 24 July 2023	2013
Wildlife Insights	Deer records from a collation of camera trapping surveys, including: Gibbons, P 2023, Canberra Urban Biodiversity Surveys - mammals, accessed 21 January 2026 Hofman, M 2024, Emuvale BTRW cameras, accessed 21 January 2026 Westaway, D & Linley, G 2021, Little Desert NP and surrounding farm patches, accessed 10 December 2025	2015-2024
Linley et al. 2025	Deer records from camera trapping survey data: Linley, GD, Jolly, CJ, Wooster, EIF, Cunningham, CX, Spencer, EE, Westaway, DM & Nimmo, DG 2025, The impact of gigafire on vegetation structure, terrestrial vertebrate abundance and diel activity, *Oikos,* e11022, DOI: 10.1002/oik.11022	2021-2022
Miritis et al. 2024	Deer records from camera trapping survey data: Miritis, V, Dickman, CR, Nimmo, DG, & Doherty, TS 2024, After the 'Black Summer' fires: Faunal responses to megafire depend on fire severity, proportional area burnt and vegetation type. *Journal of Applied Ecology,* vol. 61, pp. 63–75, DOI: 10.1111/1365-2664.14545	2020-2022

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